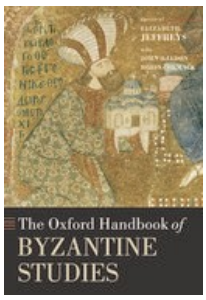


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CHAPTER

# 1.2.15 Numismatics

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## Abstract

Numismatics is the systematic study of coins with cross-disciplinary connections, having found a central role in the interpretation of the history of art, religion, politics, political geography, and economy of the ancient and medieval world. It began as part of the philosophers' approach to political science and was later systematized as a collectors' discipline and antiquarian pursuit. In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, the rapid development and systematic study of Byzantine coins paralleled the emergence of specialized coin collections in Europe and the United States. These collections followed the already established trend of the rediscovery of Byzantium. This article focuses on the beginnings of numismatics, Byzantine coinage from the reign of Anastasios I to Constantine XI, and the role of coins in religion, political ideology, and art.

**Keywords:** numismatics, coins, Byzantium, art, religion, political ideology, coinage, Anastasios I, Constantine XI, economy

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> Coins are at all times an important manifestation of contemporary art and in the days when precious metals were the accepted form of currency, coins reflected changing economic and political circumstances.
>
> P. D. Whitting

NUMISMATICS, the study of coins, has at times been perceived as an unlikely candidate to assist in the interpretation of the artistic, religious, and political history of the ancient and medieval world, or of its political geography and economy. Yet numismatics relates to all these domains, and the field's cross-

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disciplinary connections equal the numerous coin issues found across a millennium of Byzantine history. Originally discussed by philosophers as part of their approach to political science, and later systematized as a collectors' discipline and an antiquarian pursuit, numismatics has since developed dramatically, and is now firmly placed in the grounds of ancient and medieval history, archaeology, and the history of art.

## Beginnings

Numismatics is the study of coins (*nummus* = the Latin word for the lowest Roman copper denomination, *νόμισμα* = coin in ancient, medieval, and modern Greek) in terms of metrology, metallic value, fineness, mint
p. 158 attribution, and chronology, but also the study of realities in which coinage has been embedded, namely ↳ socio-economic history, political ideology, and religious practices, language, and art (Grierson 1975, 1992; Casey 1986; Morrisson 1992; Howgego 1995). The beginnings of Numismatics can be traced back to the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, when the works of Aristotle, having been made largely available to western European thinkers through Arabic translations and Byzantine commentaries, introduced them to the principles of *Politics* and *Ethics* (Langholm 1983; Laiou 1999). The study of coinage was for Christian philosophers such as Thomas Aquinas a means to analyse social structures and discuss the ideals of kingship and government. According to Aquinas' work *De Regimine Principum* coinage was central to theocratic order and kingship, as it allowed rulers to gather around them their entire populace in an organised and solid body (Sigmund 1988: 14–29). Aristotle's interpretation of coinage continued to influence philosophers such as Jean Buridan and Nicolas Oresme. The latter further developed Aristotle's approach in his study of the origins and use of coinage from antiquity to the Middle Ages. Oresme's *Traité des monnaies* summarizes the principles and use of coinage in society; coins are instruments of exchange of natural riches, they are easy to handle, light enough to carry, conform to a certain standard, and while having a stamp of authority approved and organized by the ruling power, they do not belong to a single individual, but to the entire community and its every member (Dupuy and Chartrain 1989:chs. 1–6).

The fifteenth and sixteenth centuries represent for Numismatics a turning point. The discussion of coinage moves from abstraction to meticulous recording and research of ancient coins and medals, which formed part of the first great antiquarian collections in the West. Interest in foreign and ancient coins was certainly not a new phenomenon, and references to treasure trove and coin collections can be found as early as the Roman and Byzantine period (Morrisson 1981). In the late Middle Ages Pope Boniface VIII and the poet Petrarch were among those actively engaged in the collection of ancient coins, but it was really during the Renaissance that outstanding collections of antiquities including coins were created in papal, princely, and royal circles. Between 1402 and 1413 two interesting hybrid medals were commissioned in France by the duke of Berry. The medals depicting Herakleios and Constantine the Great were, according to the inventories of the duke of Berry, based on genuine ancient medals (Jones 1979; Scher 1994). Inscriptions which display a good grasp of late Byzantine chancery formulas, and portraits of both Herakleios and Constantine based on that of the emperor Manuel II, tell a different story; both medals were ultimately based on forgeries, and they superbly mirror Manuel's visit to Paris in 1400–1, contemporary artistic sensibilities in France, and the links with antiquity western rulers and aristocracy were seeking to forge.

The study of coins as a source for ancient and medieval history further develops in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, when works by Ezechiel Spanheim (1664), Charles Patin (1665), François le Blanc (1689), Louis Jobert (1692), and Charles Du Cange (1678) lay the foundations for the methodology of
p. 159 Numismatics. Jobert's *La Science des médailles* in particular, later translated into Italian by ↳ Alessandro Pompeo Berti (*La scienza delle medaglie. Nuova edizione con annotazioni storiche e critiche, Venice* 1756), provides a first-class essay on coinage from antiquity to modern times. For Jobert Byzantine coinage was an integral part of the world of antiquity rather than an isolated phenomenon. He meticulously discussed Byzantine inscriptions, titles, and numerals alongside Roman and Greek ones. Of note are also the

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chronological boundaries within which Jobert places Byzantine coinage; late imperial coinage, as he calls it, begins with the foundation of Constantinople and ends with its fall to the Turks.

## Byzantine Coin Collections and the Study of Numismatics

In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries the rapid development and systematic study of Byzantine coins is connected to the emergence of specialized coin collections in Europe and the USA. Those collections were created in order to house high-quality coins which could tell a story, and they followed the already established trend of the rediscovery of Byzantium. Great numbers of numismatic holdings allowed nineteenth-century luminaries such as Paul de Saulcy (1836) and Pierre Justin Sabatier (1861) to classify and discuss coin series in publications which still serve as reference works. In western Europe splendid collections of Byzantine coins were established in Paris (cf. Morrisson 2001*a*), London, Vienna, Copenhagen, Rome, and Brussels. In eastern Europe, affluent individuals in Istanbul, Bucharest, Alexandria, and Athens became passionate about the collection of Byzantine coins and seals, as part of their desire to trace the cultural and political history of the former Byzantine lands. In 1926 Antonis Benakis bequeathed to the Greek state his impressive collection formed in Alexandria (Souloyannis 2004), following in the steps of the Zosimas brothers who in the mid-nineteenth century became the first major benefactors to the newly founded Numismatic Museum of Athens (1996: 15–47). In St Petersburg the Hermitage museum became noticeably richer in 1890 with the purchase *en bloc* of the famous Photiades Pasha Collection (Guruleva 1991). In Italy Tomaso Bertelè's contribution to Numismatics is not only his impressive collection, which was later to become part of the Dumbarton Oaks Collection, but also his numerous studies, with particular emphasis on the coinage of the late Byzantine empire and its relations with the west (Bertelè and Morrisson 1978). During the same period the most active collectors in Britain were undoubtedly Philip Grierson, Hugh Goodacre (1960), Simon Bendall (1988), Philip Whitting (1973), and Geoffrey Haines, the last two of whom
p. 160 founded in 1967 the Barber Institute's magnificent coin collection at the University of Birmingham. In Paris
↳ Mikelis Kursanskis meticulously recorded the story of the empire of Trebizond through his coin collection, now in the Bibliothèque nationale de France, Paris. Across the Atlantic, what was to become the most comprehensive collection of Byzantine coins worldwide (Grierson 1999*a*: 61–5) was formed at Dumbarton Oaks in Washington through major bequests and purchases made between 1947 and 1960. In New York Byzantine coins became part of the American Numismatic Society's collections in the 1940s; in 1946 the first curator of Roman and Byzantine coins was appointed, and since then the collection has continued to grow through important bequests and coin purchases.

Collections are not meant to be stagnant, obscure, or inaccessible. Their very existence greatly depends on new acquisitions, scholarship, and publication of their holdings, exhibition programmes which illuminate the art and society of particular periods, and teaching and educational activities which can make coins the sturdiest, and most accessible and versatile museum objects (Whitting 1966).

In 1908 the British Museum Trustees published Warwick Wroth's two-volume *Imperial Byzantine Coins in the British Museum.* In 1911 Wroth supplemented the two volumes with a third one dedicated to the coins of the Vandals, Ostrogoths, and Lombards, as well as the coinage of the rival empires of Thessalonike, Nicaea, and Trebizond, the state of Epiros and the Duchy of Neopatras (Wroth 1908 and 1911). It was not until 1966 that a sequel to Wroth's catalogues was published, this time by Dumbarton Oaks. The *Catalogue of the Byzantine Coins in the Dumbarton Oaks Collection and in the Whittemore Collection, vol.* 1 (*Anastasios I to Maurice*) by Alfred Bellinger is the first in a series of monumental studies which cover the whole of Byzantine coinage. Each volume drawn predominantly on the Dumbarton Oaks coin collection is a lasting testimony not only to the brilliant syntheses produced especially by Philip Grierson (1968, 1973, 1999*b*)and Michael Hendy (1969, 1999), but also to the constructive partnership between Dumbarton Oaks and Philip Grierson, who oversaw the creation of the Dumbarton Oaks Collection and served as the Dumbarton Oaks adviser for Numismatics

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until 1999. Meanwhile Cécile Morrisson in her two-volume catalogue has regrouped and thoroughly examined as entities the various coin collections of the Bibliothèque nationale which until 1963 were kept separate (Morrisson 1970).

Coins from other European coin collections found their way into shorter but important publications, which have since advanced our knowledge of Byzantine coinage (e.g. Longuet 1957). The late twentieth and the beginning of the twenty-first century witnessed further coin publications (e.g. Berger 1987; Bateson and Campbell 1998; Ireland 2000; Radić and Ivanišević 2006), which introduce researchers to a wide range of material. While catalogues in printed form will certainly continue to be produced, rapid developments in digital photography and electronic databases indicate that a more cost effective alternative is the publication of coin catalogues on the World Wide Web. The University of Birmingham Collections already p. 161 offer on their website some information on its Byzantine ↳ holdings, drawn directly from the curatorial database (http://www.numismatics.org), although there are few images available.

Numismatic exhibitions and educational programmes are also enormously beneficial especially for the general public, and certainly have the power to bring Byzantium to the fore and illustrate its profile as a financially shrewd and culturally cosmopolitan and sophisticated society. Exhibitions are also a lasting legacy of a museum's holdings, scholarship, and desire to reach and include in its programmes a wide public. Byzantine coins have frequently been featured in recent exhibition catalogues (e.g. Kalavrezou 2003; Evans 2004; Penna 2006), while the Dumbarton Oaks electronic exhibition of Byzantine coins (www.doaks.org/coins) and the Barber Institute changing exhibitions in the Coin Gallery and in their electronic form (www.barber.org.uk/coins) aim to discuss Byzantine coinage as part of Byzantium's and medieval Europe's life and culture.

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## Byzantine Coinagel: From Anastasios I to Constantine XI (Whitting 1973; Grierson 1982 And 1999*b*)

The history of Byzantine coinage starts conventionally with the reign of Anastasios, who in 491 introduced a currency reform as part of a wider platform of measures, designed to improve economic life and practices in the eastern Roman empire. The reform, carried out in two stages, was based on the Roman copper *nummus* and produced a logical system of multiples of the *nummus*, ranging from 5-*nummi* coins to 40-*nummi* ones (Fig. 1), all denominations bearing on the reverse their value in a Greek numeral, the *indictio,* and the mint-mark for all denominations above the 5-*nummi* ones. Christian symbols, such as the cross and the Chi-Rho, appear increasingly on both the obverse and reverse of the coins, but it is really in the design of the gold currency that the establishment of Christianity is best reflected (Fig. 2). Reverse images of Roman emperors spearing, or stepping on humiliated enemies gave way gradually to representations of Constantinople, the Christian new Rome of the empire, while the old Victory was being transformed into an angel carrying elaborate crosses and Chi-Rho-topped shafts. The obverse of early Byzantine gold coins was reserved for the emperor alone, while the inclusion in special occasions of his associates propagated ideas of dynastic continuity in an empire where hereditary succession was never firmly established. The copper coinage of Anastasios was further developed by Justinian I, whose military campaigns and reconquests resulted in the
p. 162 opening of new mints in the eastern and western provinces of the empire. ↳

p. 163 ↳

p. 164 ↳

p. 165 ↳

p. 166 ↳

Copper coins now bore dates of regnal year, and iconographical changes such as the introduction of the facing imperial bust (Fig. 3) further emphasized the confidence copper coinage enjoyed in the economy of the empire (Metcalf 1969; Hendy 1985; Hahn 1973, 1975, 1981, and 1989).

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(1)

**Fig. 1**

**Copper *follis* of Anastasios (491–518), large series, mint of Constantinople, officina Δ, wt 18.12 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B109; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(2)

**Fig. 2**

**Gold *solidus* of Anastasios (491–518), mint of Constantinople, wt 4.47 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B16; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(3)

**Fig. 3**

**Copper *follis* of Justinian I (527–65), mint of Antioch, officina Γ, regnal year 13 (=539/40), wt 17.45 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B792; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(4)

**Fig. 4**

**Gold *solidus* of Justinian II, second reign (705–11), mint of Constantinople, Class II, wt 4.41 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B4463; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(5)

**Fig. 5**

**Gold *solidus* of Leo IV (775–80), mint of Constantinople, Class I (776–8), wt 4.41 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B4583; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(6)

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**Fig. 8**

(9)

**Fig. 9**

**Gold *nomisma histamenon* of Nikephoros III (1078–81), mint of Constantinople, Class II, wt 4.1 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B5498; G. Haines Collection)

(10)

**Fig. 10**

(11)

**Fig. 11**

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**Gold *nomisma histamenon* of Nikephoros II (963–9), mint of Constantinople, Class II, wt 4.44 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B4928; G. Haines Collection)

**Gold *nomisma tetarteron* of Nikephoros III (1078–81), mint of Constantinople, Class II, wt 3.2 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B5502; P. D. Whitting Collection)

**Copper *follis* of Nikephoros III (1078–81), mint of Constantinople, wt 6.69 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B5510; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(12)

**Fig. 12**

**Gold *hyperpyron* of Alexios I (1081–1118), mint of Constantinople, post-reform (1092–1118), wt 4.27g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B5545; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(13)

**Fig. 13**

***Electrum trachy* of Manu 80), mint of Thessaloni**
(the Barber Institute Coi B5782; P. D. Whitting C

(15)

**Fig. 15**

**Copper *tetarteron* of John II (1118–43), mint of Thessalonike, wt 5.80 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B5673; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(16)

**Fig. 16**

**Silver *aspron* of Theodora (c. 1285), mint of Trebizond, wt 3 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection ET124; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(17)

**Fig. 17**

**Gold *hyperpyron* of Michael VIII (1258–82), mint of Constantinople, wt 4.28 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B6141; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(18)

**Fig. 18**

**Gold *hyperpyron* of John V Palaiologos with John VI Kantakouzenos (134753), mint of Constantinople, wt 3.83 g**
(the Barber Institute Coin Collection B6370; P. D. Whitting Collection)

(19)

**Fig. 19**

(20)

**Fig. 20**

**Silver *stavraton* of Joh**

The seventh and eighth centuries are in contrast a period of continuous decline of copper coins, in appearance, weight, and value, which eventually drove the smaller denominations out of circulation, leaving the *follis* as the unique copper value. Moreover, the iconoclastic controversy and succession matters are best echoed in the design of all metallic values, with religious imagery being replaced by the symbol of

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the cross, and with family portraits adorning both the obverse and reverse of gold coins (Figs. 4–6)(Frances 1966; Grierson 1968, 1973; Metcalf 2001; Morrisson 1986, 2001*b*).

In the period 820–1081 the number of single coin finds, stray or site finds, increases considerably in comparison with the previous period, sometimes called the 'Dark Ages' of Byzantium. Increase in the number of coin finds reflects expansion of coin production and circulation, which in their turn mirror imperial initiatives and the modification of fiscal practices in the Byzantine Empire. The early ninth century witnesses a major monetary reform undertaken by Theophilos, whose new copper *follis* (Fig. 7) set the pattern for the following two and a half centuries. Theophilos' reform marked the beginning of a gradual recovery of the monetized sector of the economy (Metcalf 1979). The decline in the fineness and value of gold coinage first introduced by Nikephoros II Phokas (Fig. 8)continued in the eleventh century against a backdrop of struggle between the central government and the landed aristocracy, heavy expenditure at the imperial court, continuing pressures of expenditure on defence, and the loss of considerable revenue and manpower following the Turkish advance in Asia Minor (Grierson 1973; Harvey 1989; Hendy 1985; Metcalf 1979; Morrisson 1976).

The coinage which Alexios I Komnenos had inherited from Nikephoros III was in an advanced stage of decline, with the two denominations of gold, the full-weight *histamenon* and the slightly lighter *tetarteron,* only about 8 carats fine (Figs. 9–10). The silver *miliaresion* and its fractions had virtually ceased to be issued, and even the *follis* had declined sharply in weight (Fig. 11). Alexios swept the whole system away, and replaced it with a new one whose essential feature was the use of several denominations of alloyed concave coins, uniform in weight but quite distinct in metallic content, and therefore value (Metcalf 1979; Morrisson 1979; Hendy 1985, 1999; Koutava-Delivoria 1995; for the economy at this period see Harvey 1989). The concave coins in the new system were of three denominations. A gold *hyperpyron* replaced the old *histamenon,* but although it was of traditional weight (4.5 g) it was only 20/½; carats fine (Fig. 12). Beneath it was an *electrum trachy* coin, an alloy of silver and gold, which at a fineness of 6 carats was worth roughly ⅓ of a *hyperpyron* (Fig. 13). The third denomination, known as *trachy* or *stamenon* in western sources, was an
p. 167 alloy of copper and silver (6 percent silver) and worth 1/16 of the third ↳ *hyperpyron, and* 1/48 of the full *hyperpyron* (Fig. 14). Finally at the bottom of the scale were two flat copper coins, the *tetarteron* and *half-tetarteron,* much smaller than the old *follis,* whose exchange ratio with the *trachy* is uncertain, but which may have been its eighteenth and thirty-sixth respectively (Fig. 15).

During the period of 1092–1204 there is a proliferation of religious iconography on coinage. St Demetrios, patron saint of Thessalonike, appears next to the emperor on *trachea* and *tetartera,* as symbol of civic pride and divine protection. St George, highly honoured in Constantinople, appears on *tetartera. The* Virgin Mary is depicted on most denominations holding the infant Christ or blessing the emperor. This is the beginning of a remarkable period, in which divine protection becomes increasingly visible on coins and complements the earthly one.

Shortly after the fall of Constantinople to the armies of the Fourth Crusade, the Byzantines assembled the fragments of their empire in Epiros, in north-western Anatolia, and in remote Trebizond. The coinage of the three successor states mirrors in its design the political ideology, ambitions, and struggle for legitimacy to be found in Epiros, Nicaea, and Trebizond (see Hendy 1999; Laiou 2001; Protonotarios 1983; Retowski 1910).

The recovery of Constantinople in 1261 by Michael VIII Palaiologos marks the beginning of late Byzantine coinage (Bendall and Donald 1979; Bendall 1988; Bertelè and Morrisson 1978; Grierson 1998, 1999*b*; Morrisson 1996). But the populations and markets which Palaiologan coinage was addressing were a mere shadow of twelfth-century Byzantium. The empire of Trebizond retained its independent status and continued to strike coins in the name of Megaloi Komnenoi until 1461 (Fig. 16), the kingdom of Serbia produced its first currency in 1228 (Ivanišević 2001; Jovanović 2002), and tsar Ivan Assen II (1218–41) further developed Bulgaria's legal tender (in existence since the ninth century) along the lines of Byzantine

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imperial ideology (Avdev 2005). Moreover, Latin and Venetian issues which were struck in western-dominated Byzantine territories together with Venetian and Genoese coinage that circulated along trade routes in the eastern Mediterranean dramatically reduced the diffusion of Byzantine imperial coinage (Zakythenos 1948; Laiou 1980–1; Matschke 2002). The restricted resources and limited budget of the late Byzantine empire are best reflected in the continuous reduction in the fineness of Byzantine *hyperpyra* from 15 carats under Michael VIII (Fig. 17) to 12 carats during the reign of Andronikos II. Yet, despite reduced fineness, sloppy appearance, and irregular weight, late Byzantine gold coins still succeeded in conveying messages about earthly and divine protection, sovereignty, and associate emperors. Eventually civil wars, empty treasuries, and the increasingly strong presence of Italian maritime powers in the eastern Mediterranean prompted Byzantium to cease striking gold by replacing it with silver. The last *hyperpyra,* struck by John V in association with John VI (Fig. 18), mark the end of a millennium of gold currency in the eastern Roman empire. Silver, by contrast, was produced on a great scale. The *basilikon* (Fig. 19), introduced
p. 168 by Andronikos II, was modelled after the silver ducat of Venice. In the ↳ second half of the fourteenth century the silver *stavraton* (Fig. 20) introduced by John aimed to take over the functions previously fulfilled by the now abandoned gold coinage. The last *stavrata* and their denominations (Fig. 21) were issued by Constantine XI Palaiologos in 1453 (Bendall 1991). Contemporary records together with recent metallurgical analysis suggest that the source for this coinage might have been church plates—a reflection of the desperation on the eve of Constantinople's fall to the Ottomans. It is not until 1467 that gold coinage was once more struck in Constantinople. The name of the city on the coins was now stated as Constantinia, and the universal ruler who ruled over the lands and seas of the former Roman Empire was Mehmet II the Conqueror.

## Past, Current, and Future Directions

Studies related to Byzantine coins can ordinarily be seen in numismatic periodicals and series produced by leading numismatic societies. The appearance of coin studies in such arenas has been sufficient for some to label numismatics as a narrow discipline, associated mostly with collections and die-studies. This common perception does not correspond to reality, and the ever growing number of art historical, archaeological, and economic studies on coin iconography, distribution, and circulation demonstrate the importance numismatic evidence holds as source material, with naturally all the limitations any other group of Byzantine sources has. The very nature of numismatic evidence gives even some advantages to coins over other sources. Coins continue to turn up in large numbers in archaeological sites and accidental finds, and their publication and consideration in regional and cross-cultural studies is still far from completed. In that respect coins can be a rich source and a true kaleidoscope through which various aspects of Byzantine civilization continue to emerge. Hence the short discussion that follows does not intend to categorize coins in typologies, but rather to demonstrate their versatility as a tool for the study of Byzantine civilization.

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## Coins, Religion, Political Ideology, and Art

Though mostly conservative in their approach, coins capture artistic trends of their time, and try to convey messages of imperial ideology and theological discourse as the mass, and therefore powerful, medium of art of their time. Hairstyle, imperial dress code, and insignia as well as the very presence or absence of
p. 169 Byzantine empresses on coins, are subjects that certainly have not exhausted discussion and ↳ research (Tobler and Brubaker 2000). The partnership between divine and earthly powers, as this is illustrated on coins, is also an intriguing area of research (e.g. Georganteli 2001; Morrisson 2003). Angels first appear on coins as early as the fifth century as part of the Christianization of the empire, but it was really Justinian II and later Leo VI who introduced splendid images of Christ and the Virgin Mary on their coins (Penna 2000), and provided the base for the development of a great repertoire of saintly figures pictured alone and later in the company of emperors.

## Coin Production and the Economy

Throughout its millennium the Byzantine state retained a key role in the planning and issuing of coinage by controlling some of the most important aspects of its economy, such as interest rates, maritime trade, taxation, salaries of state officials and the army. This centralized character, similar to the economic planning conducted by modern states, was in contrast to the regional aspects of economy encountered in western medieval Europe. Byzantine coins were struck in gold, silver, and copper, and the availability or dearth of certain denominations or metallic values throughout Byzantium's existence, as well as the emergence and disappearance of imperial mints, was in tune with contemporary socio-economic and political phenomena that dominated the life of the empire (Hendy 1985; Laiou and Morrisson 2007; Oikonomides 1996).

A very interesting aspect of the Byzantine economy is the relation between coins, taxation, wages, and prices. References to taxes and prices expressed in coins can be found in a variety of sources including imperial charters, historiography, saints' lives, monastic typica, and satire. Useful studies of these in relation to the state's economic apparatus can be found in Oikonomides (1996), Morrisson and Cheynet (2002), and Lefort (1991).

## Coinage, Medieval Routes, and Communications

The study of Byzantine coinage is essentially the study of routes and communications within and outside Byzantium's borders, of the empire's political and socio-economic evolution, and of its cultural and religious interchange with its eastern and western neighbours. In that respect any attempt to single out Byzantine numismatics from political geography, history, and archaeology as well as from western medieval, Balkan, and Islamic numismatics may appear oversimplification to the point of distortion.

In terms of the circumstances of discovery, coins are classified as site finds (coins unearthed in the process of archaeological work) and stray finds (coins accidentally found during surveys, mining, agricultural
p. 170 activities, etc.). In terms of ↳ numbers, coin finds are categorized as single and accumulative ones or coin hoards, and the study of each group calls for a different methodological approach (see e.g. Morrisson 1982; Gelichi and La Roca 2004). Systematization of archaeological research and recent developments in the recording of portable antiquities, which include coins, have undoubtedly advanced our knowledge of the role of coinage, both Byzantine and foreign, in the medieval economy, and of the routes of trade, war, and pilgrimage across the Balkans, the eastern Mediterranean, and the Black Sea (Duncan 1993; McCormick 2001; Morrisson, Popovic, and Ivanišević 2006; Oberländer-Târnoveanu 2001). A major *desideratum* for future research remains the discussion of coin finds in their own socio-economic context shaped by the political and economic geography of the medieval Balkans rather than that determined by modern national

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borders in the peninsula. In that respect the field of numismatics still has room for improvement, especially with respect to the wider usage of written sources, the utilization of maps of Byzantine administrative units, and the systematic mapping of find-spots.

## Byzantine Coinage Between East and West, and from Rome to Rum

The complexity of Byzantium's diplomatic, economic, and artistic relations with its eastern and western neighbours has generated a substantial volume of research in documents and artefacts (see Laiou and Morrisson 2001). Yet, numismatic studies on this topic are still conspicuously few. Given the ever growing number of publications of Byzantine coin finds from Armenia, Georgia, China, northern and western Europe, the setting of Byzantine coins in their eastern and western context is not only desirable but also a fresh and essential angle of research (see Georganteli and Cook 2006). The area of the eastern Mediterranean was always a natural crossroads for different cultures brought together by trade, political expediency, and warfare. The coinage of the crusader principalities and kingdoms, of the empires of Trebizond and Nicaea, and of the kingdom of Cilician Armenia reflects in its iconography, metrology, and metallic system a strong current of cross-cultural exchange between East and West. Moreover, encounters between Byzantium and the Islamic world from the emergence of the first Islamic coinage in the seventh century to the Ottoman conquest in the fifteenth century, are superbly reflected in the iconographical choices and metallic values of seventh-century Islamic coins, the coinage of the Turkish princes and chieftains of eleventh-thirteenth century Anatolia, and the coins (for a bibliographical survey see Oddy 2004) and medals issued by Mehmet II in the 1470s and 1480s.

All these research areas call for comparative studies and an interdisciplinary approach which can bring into
p. 171 the discussion socio-economic history, political ↳ geography, and the study of art. This interdisciplinary approach, already exercised in western medieval studies, can eventually achieve a better understanding of Byzantium's most powerful mass medium of communication, its coinage.

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## Further Reading

The International Numismatic Commission has produced since 1940 fourteen surveys of numismatic research, each volume to coincide with the International Numismatic Congress hosted by different countries every six years. The surveys are meticulous and up-to-date accounts of the scholarship produced worldwide. See also C. Morrisson, 'Byzance', in C. Alfaro and A. Burnett (eds.), *A Survey of Numismatic Research, 1996–2001* (Madrid, 2003): 347–74. Other specialized publications featuring studies on Byzantine coins are periodicals by learned societies worldwide: the *Numismatic Chronicle* (Royal Numismatic Society), the *Numismatic Circular* (Spink), la *Revue numismatique* (La Société Française de Numismatique), la *Revue belge de numismatique* (La Société royale de numismatique de Belgique), la *Rivista Italiana di Numismatica* (La Società Numismatica Italiana), *Schweizer Münzblätter* (Societé Suisse de Numismatique), *Numismatic Litterature* (American Numismatic Society), *Nomismatika Chronica* (Hellenic Numismatic Society), *Studii şi Cercetări de Numismatică* (Academia Romana), *Numismatika I Sfragistika* (Arkheologicheski Muzei, Sofia), and the *Macedonian Numismatic Journal* (Skopje).

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## Coins in Art

Useful discussions of Byzantine coins in the context of contemporary art, imperial ideology, and religious practices are found in Grierson 1968 and 1973, and Hendy 1999. See also D. Vassilikou and M. Lykiardopoulou (eds.), *Coinage and Religion* (*ΟΒΟΛΟΣ* 2) (Athens, 1997).

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## Coin Production and the Economy

This is a huge topic; useful orientation can be found in *EHB*. Important also are Hendy 1985, Laiou-Thomadakis 1977, Treadgold 1982, and Kravari, Lefort, and Morrisson 1989–91, Laiou and Morrisson 2007.

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